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Retailer Churn and Food Access

Twenty years of SNAP retailer entry and exit, and what a single-date access map cannot show

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MOTIVATION

Food access is measured as distance on a single date

The standard measure

Share of a tract's population living more than 1 mile (urban) or 10 miles (rural) from a food store, the convention of USDA's Food Access Research Atlas.

What changed in July 2026

ERS released the SNAP-authorized Retailer Access Map (SRAM). It measures distance to every SNAP-authorized store, including convenience stores and small groceries, not only supermarkets.

What it still cannot show

SRAM uses the retailer list as of June 2025. It records which stores were nearby on that date, but not how long those stores stay.

Sources: USDA ERS, Food Access Research Atlas documentation (2026); SRAM data, initial release July 2026.

The stores SRAM adds are the ones that come and go

Evidence on small formats

- Convenience stores were **44%** of SNAP retailers but **5%** of SNAP redemptions in FY2024 (USDA FNS 2026).
- Dollar-store entry is associated with the exit of other small-format stores, not grocery stores (Chenarides, Çakır and Richards 2024).
- Byrne et al. (2024): the 2008–2012 expansion of SNAP retailers lowered shopping costs, so the stock matters for households.

The measurement problem

- If nearby stores enter and exit often, a single-date map overstates how reliable access is.
- In administrative data, an authorization ending is not the same as a store closing: owners change, authorizations lapse and return, and records are closed in batches.
- The studies reviewed here do not separate these cases or report national turnover rates.

Three questions and three contributions

Research questions

- **How often** do SNAP retailers exit once administrative record changes are separated from real departures?
- **Which stores and which places** carry the most turnover?
- **How much** of the access in the June 2025 SRAM snapshot is recent?

Contributions

- Three nested definitions of exit: record, store and location.
- A national panel of SNAP retailer turnover, 2006–2024, by store type and county poverty.
- A link between the retailer panel and SRAM's reference month, showing how recent mapped access is.

The analysis is descriptive. It documents patterns and does not estimate causal effects.

Two public USDA files, linked at the county level

703,441 records

SNAP Retailer Locator, historical file

Every retailer authorized at any time from 2005 to 2025 (current to 31 Dec 2025): store type, street address, county, coordinates, authorization and end dates.

84,119 tracts

SNAP-authorized Retailer Access Map

84,119 2020 census tracts: population, poverty, SNAP households, and low-income/low-access flags. Aggregated to 3,143 counties, weighted by population.

Sample construction	Records
Raw historical file	703,441
Less farmers markets and delivery routes (also excluded by SRAM)	-11,948
Less records outside the 50 states and DC	-1,240
Less records ending before they begin	-45
Analysis sample (649,325 retailers; 99.99% matched to a county)	690,208

What counts as an exit? Three nested definitions

E0 · Record exit

Any authorization end date. What a simple count of the file measures.

E1 · Store exit

A retailer's authorization ends and the same retailer is not re-authorized within 365 days.

E2 · Location loss

An address stops hosting any SNAP store, and no new SNAP store opens there within 365 days.

Example: one address in the Bronx, New York (ZIP 10457)

Retailer at the address	Authorized	Ended
Retailer 1	May 2004	June 2006
Retailer 2 (opened 12 weeks later)	August 2006	November 2013
Retailer 3	April 2015	August 2016
Retailer 4	September 2022	still open

Three store exits (E1), but only two location losses (E2): the 2006 exit was followed by a new SNAP store within a year.

MEASUREMENT

How much the continuity window matters

Window (days)	Store exit, %/yr (E1)	Location loss, %/yr (E2)
0	9.51	8.92
30	9.20	6.80
180	8.96	5.57
365	8.79	5.00
730	8.77	4.56

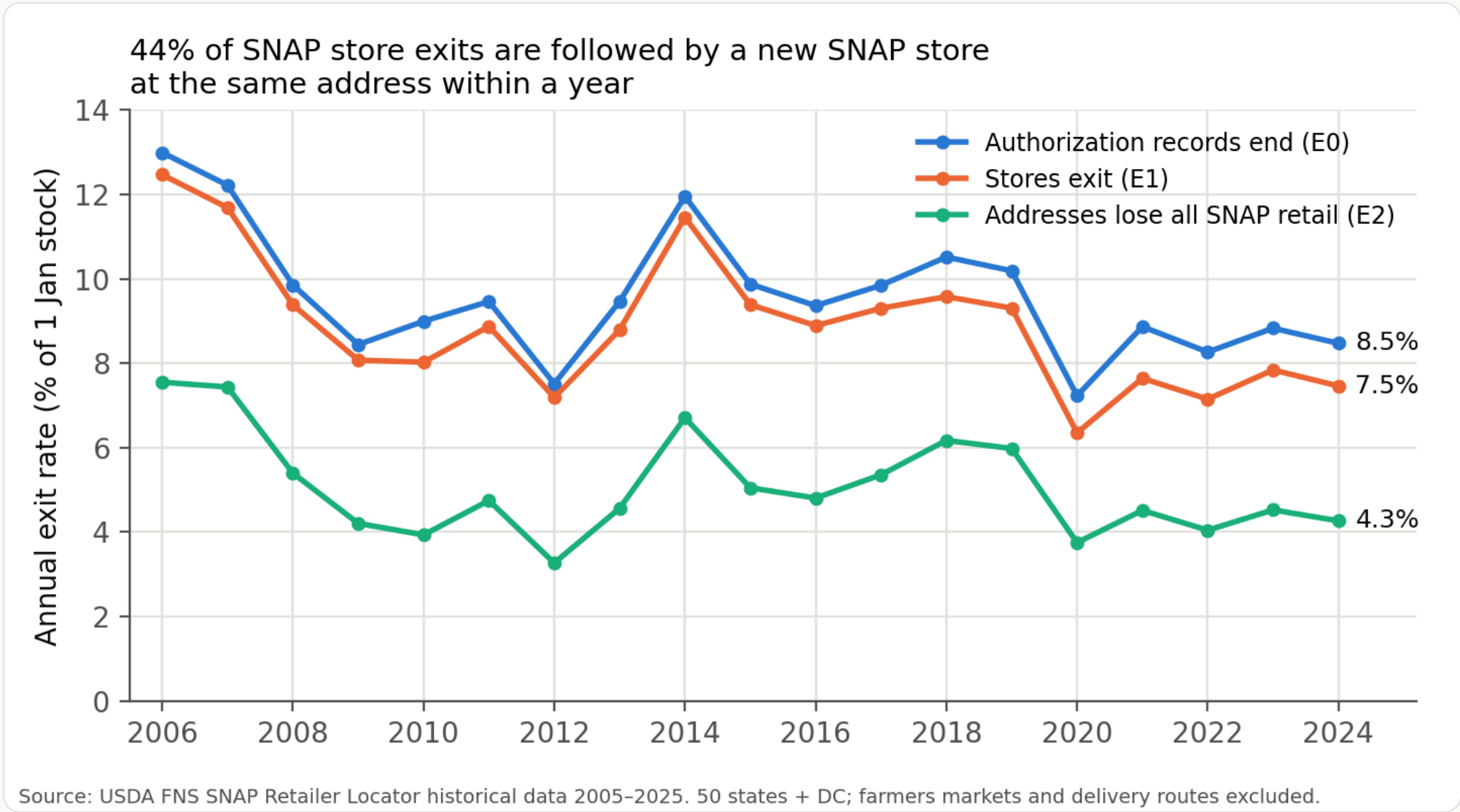
Average annual rates. The 730-day window counts exits through 2023.

Reading the table

- Store exit barely moves: re-authorization of the same retailer is uncommon.
- Location loss is sensitive: at 30 days 26.1% of store exits are replaced in place; at 365 days, 43.6%.
- 52 end dates each close 1,000+ records nationally; 27.2% of store exits fall on them.

RESULT 1 · HOW OFTEN

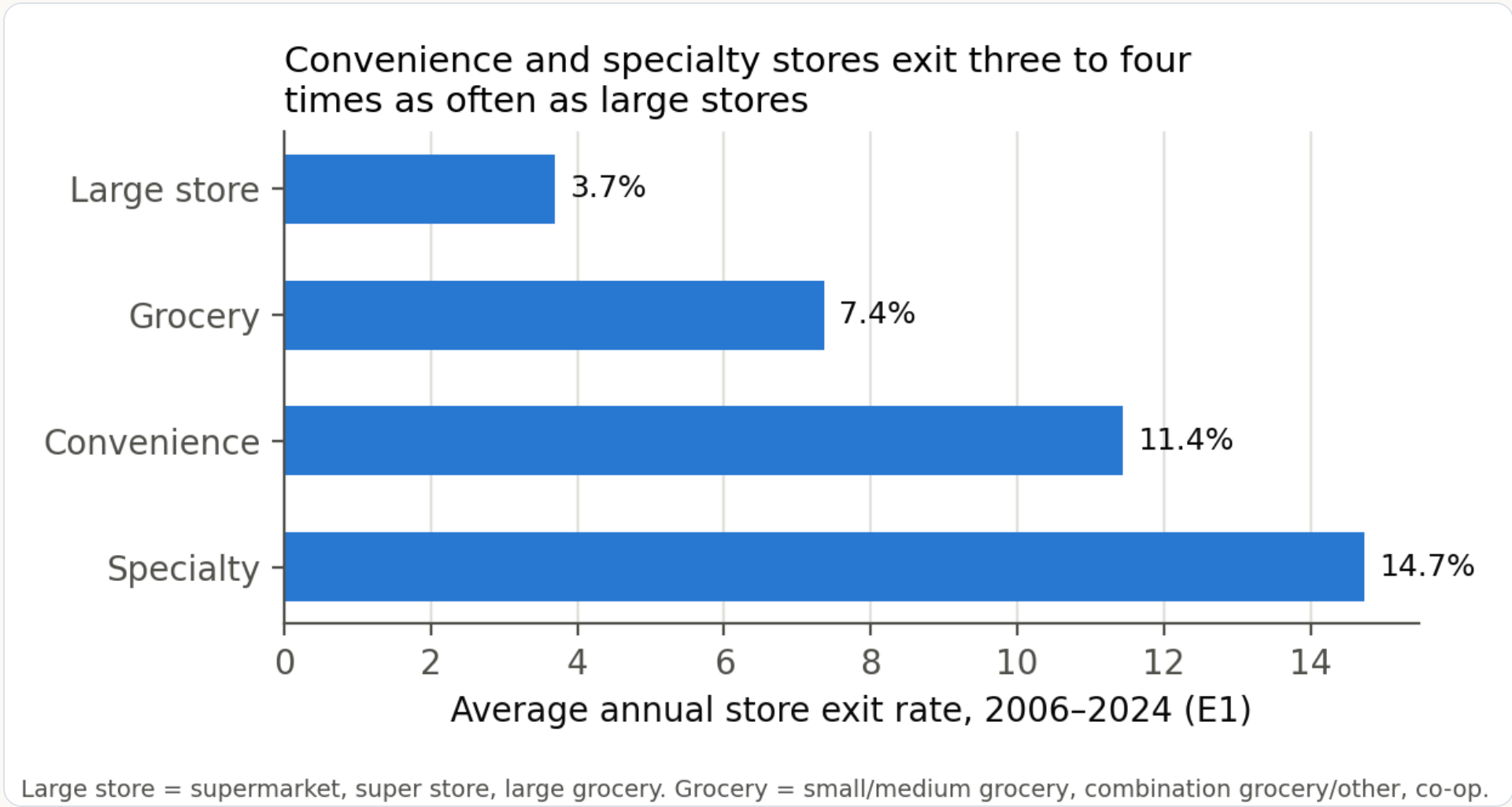
43.6% of store exits are replaced at the same address within a year



- Stores exit at **8.8%** a year on average.
- Addresses lose all SNAP retail at **5.0%** a year.
- Counting record end dates as closures overstates location loss by about **90%**.
- Stock grew from 157,611 (2006) to 248,912 (2024); entry peaked at 21.3% in 2009.

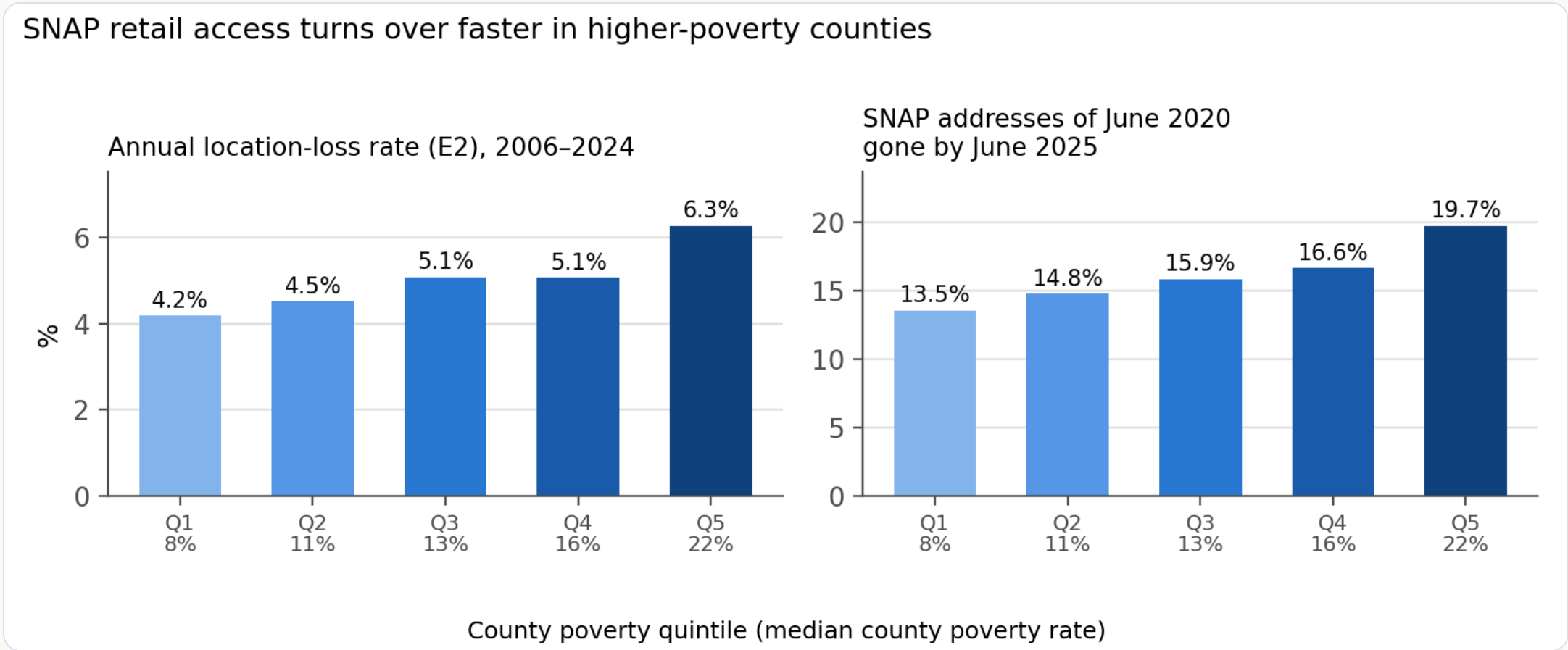
RESULT 2 · WHICH STORES

Small formats carry most of the turnover



- Large stores exit at **3.7%** a year; convenience stores at **11.4%**, about three times as often.
- Convenience stores are **44.8%** of all SNAP store-years, so they account for most exits.
- Specialty stores exit fastest (14.7%) but are only 3.8% of the stock.
- SRAM counts all of these formats as access.

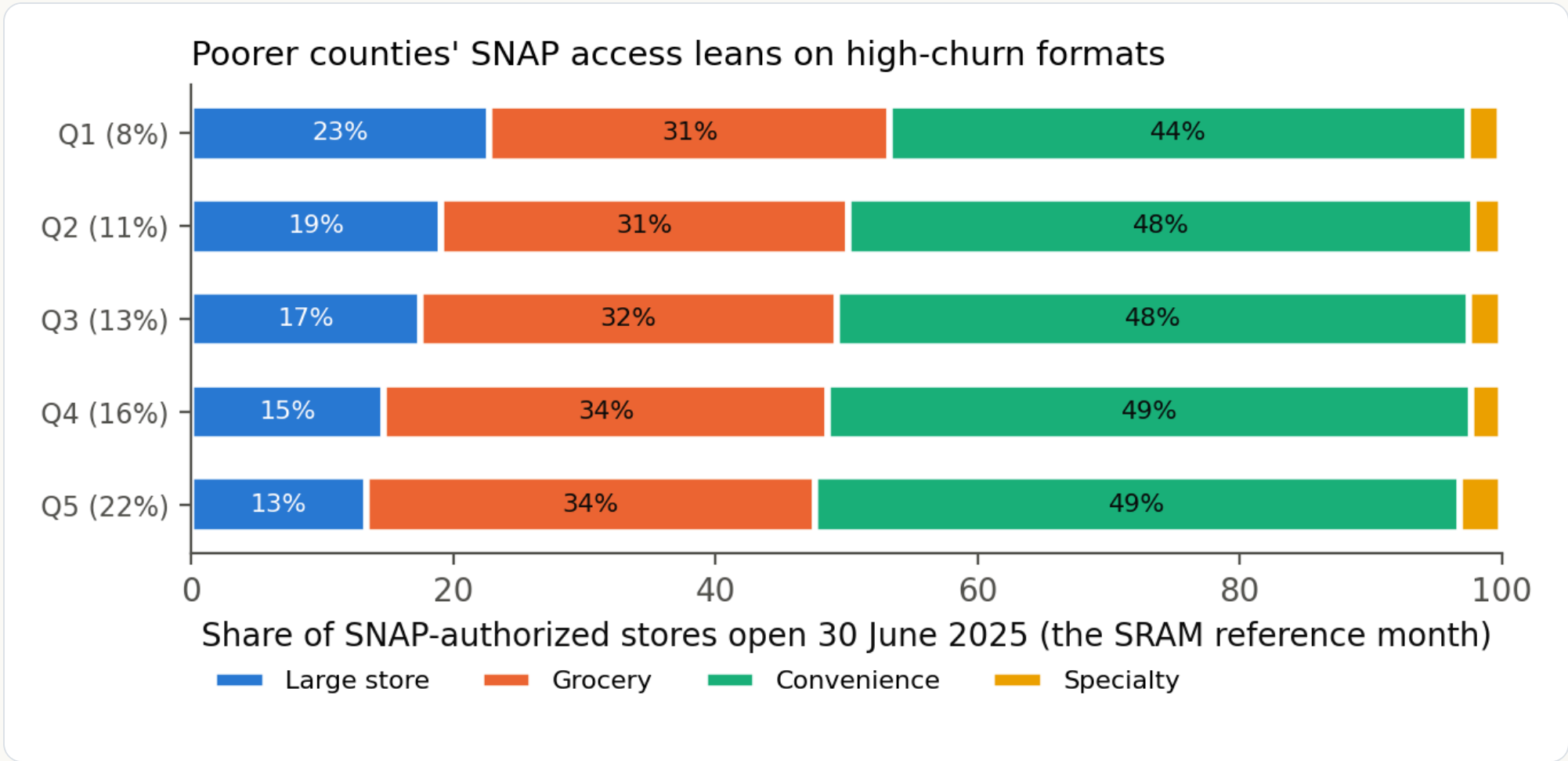
Access turns over faster in higher-poverty counties



- Annual location loss rises from **4.2%** to **6.3%** across poverty quintiles (1.50×).
- Poorest fifth of counties: **19.7%** of June 2020 SNAP addresses gone by June 2025.
- Least-poor fifth: **13.5%**.
- More of the 2025 stock is also new in poorer counties (22.2% vs 18.5%).

County poverty rate from the 2020–2024 ACS via SRAM. Quintile medians: 7.8% (Q1) to 22.1% (Q5); 3,126 counties.

Poorer counties rely more on high-turnover formats



- Large stores are **22.7%** of SNAP stores in the least-poor counties and **13.3%** in the poorest.
- Convenience stores: 44.1% vs 49.2%.
- Stores counted as open on 30 June 2025, SRAM's reference month.
- Does this mix explain the poverty gap? Next slide.

WHY THE GAP?

Store mix explains only about a quarter of the poverty gap

24%

of the gap in store exit rates between the poorest and least-poor fifths is due to store mix (shift-share).

Poorest fifth: **10.91%** a year. Least poor: **7.22%**. Poorest fifth with the least-poor mix: **10.02%**.

Store exit rate within each format, %/yr

Store group	Least poor	Poorest
Large store	3.3	4.4
Grocery	6.2	9.9
Convenience	10.0	13.0
Specialty	12.6	15.7

The same kind of store exits more often in poorer counties.

CONDITIONAL ASSOCIATIONS

Poverty predicts turnover; the map's own access flag does not

County characteristic	(1) Location loss	(2) Location loss	(3) Store exit	(4) Lost 2020–25
Poverty rate, per 10 pp	1.31*** (0.12)	1.42*** (0.11)	2.68*** (0.31)	3.78*** (0.53)
LILA population share, per 0.1	-0.10* (0.05)	-0.09* (0.05)	-0.24*** (0.09)	-0.22 (0.16)
Urban population share, per 0.1	-0.15*** (0.03)	-0.14*** (0.03)	-0.08* (0.05)	-0.19* (0.11)
Convenience share of stores, per 0.1		-0.30*** (0.11)		
Counties	3,112	3,112	3,112	3,112

- A 10-point higher poverty rate is associated with a location-loss rate 1.31 points higher, against a mean of 5.00%.
- Column 2: holding the convenience-store share fixed leaves the poverty coefficient about the same.
- The low-income, low-access (LILA) share is not positive once poverty is held fixed; 62.5% of counties have no LILA population when every SNAP store counts.

WLS, weights = county stock; state fixed effects and log population included; SEs clustered by state in parentheses. *** p<0.01, ** p<0.05, * p<0.1. Descriptive, not causal.

[BACK TO THE MAP](#)

How recent is the access in the June 2025 snapshot?

247,300

SNAP retail addresses, June 2025

The locations behind SRAM's retailer list.

19.7%

New since June 2020

Addresses that were not SNAP retail locations five years earlier.

16.0%

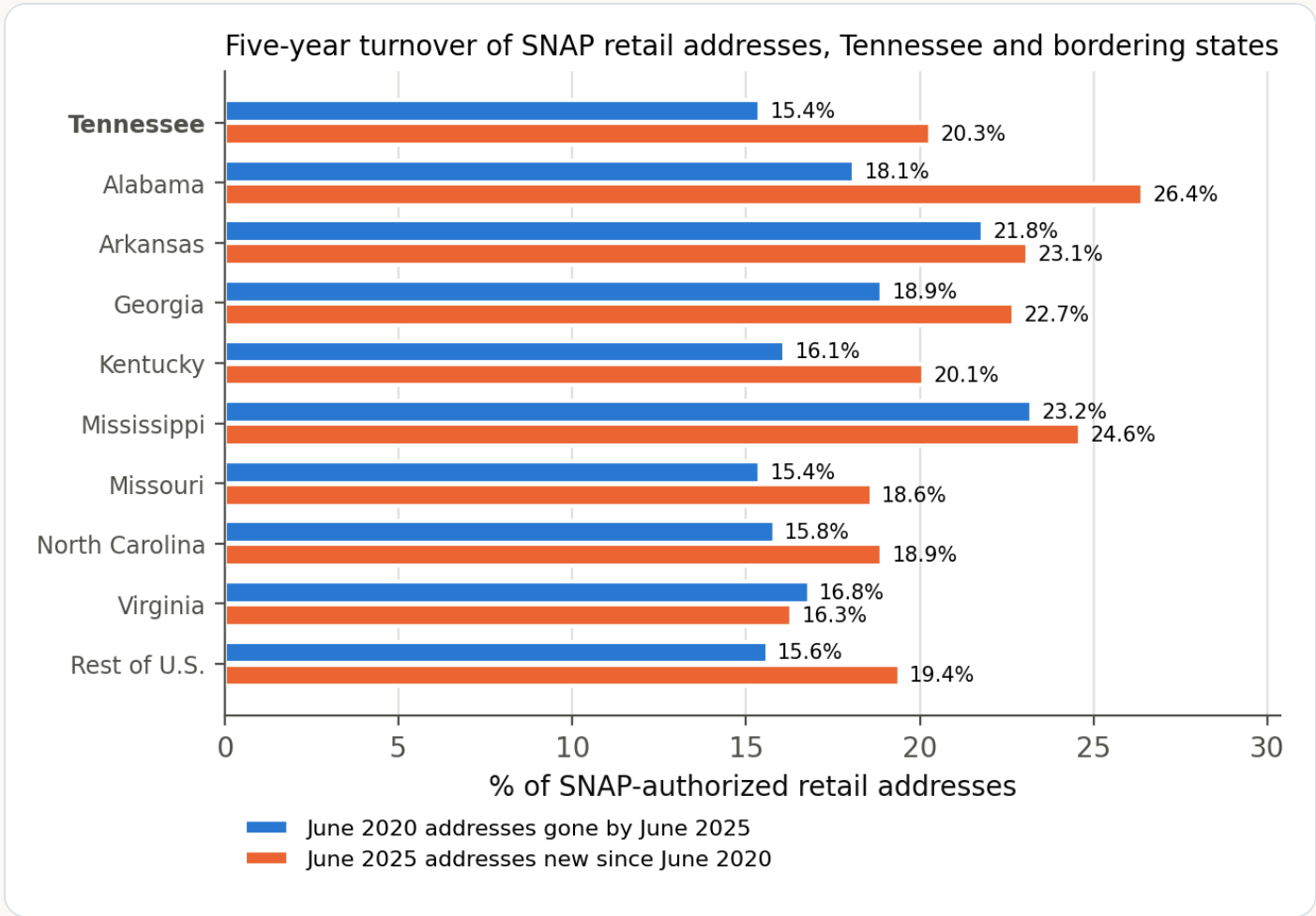
Gone since June 2020

June 2020 SNAP retail addresses no longer active in June 2025.

- About one in five mapped access points is less than five years old.
- In the poorest fifth of counties, 22.2% of 2025 addresses are new and 19.7% of 2020 addresses are gone.
- A map release paired with a persistence measure would separate stable access from access that depends on one store.

A REGIONAL ILLUSTRATION

Tennessee and its neighbors: poorer, more rural, similar turnover



	Poverty %	Loss %/yr	Lost 20–25	New 20–25
Tennessee	15.7	5.1	15.4	20.3
Bordering states (8)	16.7	5.6	17.7	20.9
Rest of U.S.	12.4	4.9	15.6	19.4

Why this region: a contiguous southern region that is poorer and more rural than the rest of the country, with a higher share of people in low-income, low-access tracts.

Rutherford County, Tennessee (Murfreesboro): location loss 4.3% a year; 26.1% of its 253 SNAP addresses in 2025 were new since 2020.

POLICY RELEVANCE

Updated SNAP stocking standards take effect November 4, 2026

- Existing retailers must stock seven varieties in each staple food category, up from three (91 FR 25082, May 8, 2026).
- The rule notes that in low-access areas "one nearby convenience store may be the only access point for buying food."
- Small formats already have the highest exit rates, and poorer counties rely on them most.
- Only a location-level measure (E2) can tell a retailer leaving SNAP apart from a community losing SNAP retail.

LIMITATIONS

What these data can and cannot tell us

Measurement

- SNAP authorization is not the same as a store being open.
- Some end dates are administrative (52 batch dates).
- The 365-day continuity window is a judgment; results are shown for 0–730 days.
- Address matching is literal: spelling variants overstate location loss; shared addresses understate it.

Scope and design

- County level: SRAM is a tract product, and tract assignment of stores is the next step.
- SRAM access flags are measured once, in 2025.
- All associations are descriptive, with state fixed effects; none is causal.
- Redemption-weighted exit is not possible with public store-level data.

CONCLUSIONS

Food access is a flow as well as a stock

1 · Measure exit by place

Record counts overstate lost access: 9.5% vs 5.0% a year. 43.6% of store exits are replaced in place.

2 · Turnover is unequal

Poorer counties lose SNAP retail addresses faster (19.7% vs 13.5% over five years), mostly within store types.

3 · Read maps with turnover

19.7% of the addresses behind the June 2025 SRAM snapshot were new since 2020.

Next steps

- Tract-level assignment of stores: did tracts with access in 2025 have it five years earlier, and will they keep it?
- Measure exits around the November 2026 stocking-standards compliance date with the next FNS file.

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Thank you

Comments and questions welcome

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Code, data and QA report: github.com/Tlayem/retailer-churn · doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.22884651